

Risk, Dignity of Risk, Lone Work & WHS

Balance participant choice with safe systems of work

Suggested training type: Read + mini quiz Suggested pass mark: 80% Review/validity: 12 months recommended review cycle

Learning objectives

- Understand dignity of risk and why zero-risk support is not the goal.
- Identify common hazards in disability support and community work.
- Apply lone-worker and external-venue safety principles.
- Know when a task requires specific manual handling or other competency.

1. Dignity of risk

People with disability have the same right as others to make choices that involve ordinary risk. Workers should not remove choice merely because a safer option exists. The worker's role is to support informed decisions while following lawful, proportionate safety controls and the participant's agreed support arrangements.

2. Common disability-support hazards

- Manual and participant handling.
- Slips, trips and falls.
- Working alone or in unfamiliar homes and community venues.
- Violence and aggression.
- Driving and travel.
- Fatigue and psychosocial hazards.
- Environmental, equipment and infection hazards.

3. Lone and remote work

SafeWork NSW specifically recognises health and community workers in other people's homes as potentially remote or isolated workers. Before and during lone work, workers should know the check-in process, emergency contacts, communication method, escalation triggers, travel arrangements and what to do if they feel unsafe.

4. Community and external venues

When supporting a participant at a medical appointment, park, event, shop or other venue, that location becomes part of the workplace. Consider accessibility, transport, weather, emergency access, participant-specific risks and the worker's own health and safety.

5. Practical competency limits

Reading this module does not make someone competent in participant lifting, hoists, transfers, restrictive practices, complex medication support or high-intensity supports. Those tasks require role-specific assessment, training and, where applicable, qualified or supervised competency.

Knowledge Check

Choose the best answer for each question. Suggested pass mark: 80%. This quiz checks understanding of the module; it does not replace supervised practical competency where that is required.

1. What does dignity of risk recognise?
 - A. Participants must avoid all risk
 - B. People have the right to make informed choices that can involve ordinary risk
 - C. Workers can ignore hazards
 - D. Safety procedures never apply

2. Which can be a lone-work risk?
 - A. Poor access to emergency help
 - B. Violence or aggression
 - C. Communication failure
 - D. All of the above

3. Does an external community venue become part of the workplace during support?
 - A. No
 - B. Yes
 - C. Only hospitals
 - D. Only if the shift exceeds 4 hours

4. Does completing this PDF make a worker competent to use a hoist?
 - A. Yes
 - B. No
 - C. Only if they score 100%
 - D. Only on weekends

5. What should a worker know before lone work?
 - A. Check-in and emergency/escalation arrangements
 - B. Nothing special
 - C. Only participant's favourite food
 - D. Only payroll details

Manager answer key is included in the accompanying quiz JSON file.

Source and reference notes

This Opus Care resource is an original internal training summary. It is based on current public guidance and does not reproduce third-party courses. Workers should use the linked official resources where specified.

- <https://www.safework.nsw.gov.au/your-industry/health-care-and-social-assistance/disability-support>
- <https://www.safework.nsw.gov.au/hazards-a-z/remote-and-isolated-work>
- <https://www.ndiscommission.gov.au/workforce/training-workers/guide-for-ndis-providers/training-your-workers>

Important: Internal completion does not create a nationally recognised qualification, professional licence, or practical competency. Opus Care should verify external qualifications and practical skills appropriate to each worker's role and the supports actually delivered.